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Tom Porrello

Tom Porrello has played trumpet with a lengthy list of artists, including Stan Kenton, Elvis Presley, Harry James, and Lady Gaga. He was a first-call player in Las Vegas, playing as many as six shows a day, and in 2023 he is still an active musician. As a lead trumpeter, he is known for his endurance and consistency in reaching the upper limits of the instrument.

Tom was interviewed via Zoom on March 6, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Tommy Porrello with me this afternoon. And we're many miles apart but I'm looking forward to speaking with you. A mutual friend described you as "the quintessential lead trumpet player."

TP: That's nice.

MR: It is nice. I've always wanted to be a quintessential something. But it's nice that he pointed that out. I'm curious about what kind of music was going on in your household when you were young, and can you recall something that made a distinct impression on you back then?

TP: Okay well yeah, in my household my father is a musician. He was a saxophone player. His brother, my uncle, was a drummer. And my other uncle was an arranger and a piano player and he played tuba. And my father had the Italian feast bands where they, you know, they always pin the money on the thing. And so I started playing with that little band when I was like eight and I was playing drums then. And my mother thought the drums were a little bit noisy and, much to her chagrin, I ended up with the trumpet which is as bad as the drums as far as she was concerned. So yeah I had a lot of influence, family influence.

MR: They have one of those bands here in nearby Utica, it's called the Red Band. And I find them a fascinating social thing with the men and women marching around and the stamina it must have taken for some of those events.

TP: Yeah. We would start the feast on the day before and we would start at 8 in the morning. Italian bands, however, don't march in step, they just walk. They don't march in step, they just walk and play. Because all the marches, the old Italian marches, they're like little overtures, They're not like "Stars and Stripes Forever" all the way through it. They're very musical and everybody doesn't play at once and it's like a little mini-overture. So we used to do that 8 to 12 noon, and take a break and then go across the river to New Jersey and play from 1 'til like 4:30, and then at night we would do a concert

numbers while they shot the fireworks. And we did the same thing the next day. And four trumpets. We all did all of it. And I guess nobody ever told us we were supposed to get tired. But we just played. It took a lot of endurance. Along those lines, while I was doing "Funny Girl" we opened in Boston and I took a couple lessons with Armando Ghitalla and the first thing he asked me, I played something and he liked it and he said, "Tell me a little bit about your background." And I told him I played — my father has an Italian band and I played all those Italian marches and things. He said, "That's good enough. I know about them" he said.

MR: I find it deliciously ironic that I was listening to another interview with you and you were describing something that we'll get to eventually today but playing in Las Vegas and your day ran from 2 PM to 4 AM. It almost sounds like the same schedule, like 50 years later.

TP: Yeah. Well that's — I think what Armando was talking about was the endurance thing. And if you played with those bands for a weekend you'd better have some pretty strong chops.

MR: I've never read specifically about this but New Orleans was a very cosmopolitan city with all kinds of ethnic traditions. And I wonder if the street parades back then were partly an Italian occurrence.

TP: I don't know. I never gave that any thought, to be honest.

MR: Yeah.

TP: Yeah, that's possible.

MR: It sounds like someone's Ph.D. exploration to me.

TP: Yeah. My father also had like the number one of then back in those days they called it the dance bands. So he was like the most popular band in town. So I started playing with that also, that when I was 16 because I had to join the union and I had to wait 'til I was 16.

MR: I was going to ask about that, do you remember what it cost? This would have been a union of which city?

TP: Easton Pennsylvania.

MR: Okay. What did it cost to join the union, can you recall? Say that again?

TP: About five dollars, if that.

MR: And did you have to audition?

TP: No.

MR: Yeah. Just like "What do you play?" "Trumpet" "How many valves?" "Three." "You're in."

TP: You got it. Like they say it must be an easy instrument to play because you've only got three things to push.

MR: Along those lines, I read a sort of coincidental, this phrase that we hear sometimes referring to a life in the arts. And the phrase is, "If you find a job you like you'll never work a day in your life." Which sounds really nice but it sort of indicates that it's an easy life. Would you describe what you do as easy?

TP: No. No. Of all the instruments probably the trumpet is by far the most physical. So you have to be in — keep yourself in shape, you've got to keep your body in shape. Because there's like so many little things just to produce one note, so many things have to synchronize right at the right time. And it's very difficult. But it becomes a passion and then it's not work anymore. Then it's not work. It's — so I think that's where that phrases came about "I never worked a day in my life." When it becomes a passion — like I'm still playing now, you know you can't put it down. It's almost addicting you know.

MR: Did you ever have a period where the passion ebbed? Or that the music that you started to play regularly did not appeal to you?

TP: Well like I started with my father's band you know. We basically played the stock arrangements you know that you could buy at a music store and stuff like that. But it was a big band, you know, three trumpets, a couple trombones, five saxophones. So it was nice with that. Then when the rock thing came in that kind of alleviated the horns pretty much. There weren't a lot of trumpet on those things. But everything we did, even in high school we started a jazz band which was unheard of in those days. And even in college we started a jazz band which was really unheard of in those days. And so we could play, we had good charts the guys were writing for it and they were just fun. The playing is, like I say when it becomes a passion it's fun so it's never really work I don't think. You forget about the physical part.

MR: Until it comes around and bites you, right?

TP: Yeah well, it does come back and bite you too. Yeah, trumpets —I like what Dizzy Gillespie always said, "the trumpet — one day you play the trumpet and you win. The next day you play the trumpet the trumpet wins. Then you die and the trumpet wins again." That was Dizzy's quote.

MR: That's a good one. There's something about, you know you mentioned that you started a jazz band in high school and then in college. There's something about that initiative that makes the music that much more enjoyable and your passion for it. Because you're doing it on your own without any requirement, that you're here because you want to be.

TP: Right. Exactly. Exactly.

MR: Did you see into the — well you're a young man and you're thinking this is going to be my career, what are my opportunities here? What should I look to be doing?

TP: Well I had my eye set on — I got the tail end of the big bands. I played — maybe you

and different bands that came to town featuring Easton's young trumpet player. Anyway then I think maybe you know this too, in that band that I played with that was Maynard and Buddy Childers and Conte Candoli — all the heavyweights you know — Bob Cooper, Art Pepper, all those guys. And I saw those guys get on that band bus and man I was drooling. I said I've got to get on that band bus someday. So I wanted to be a lead trumpet with that band someday. And it came to pass.

MR: I know what you're saying. I remember my parents taking me to see the Glenn Miller orchestra. It was long after Glenn was gone of course, but I stood in front of the sax section and said, "I want to do that, I want to do that" without knowing of course what anything about what the life was like.

TP: That's right.

MR: But that didn't matter at that point.

TP: No it didn't matter at all. But I say like watching those guys get on the band bus I said oh man I've got to do that someday. And I got to do it and then that's the hardest part of the job is that band bus you know. With Stan Kenton you know I was with the mellophone band and playing lead trumpet with four mellophones, five trumpets and five trombones is kind of a chore. But it was a fun chore. But jeez, the bus, you know we had such a large band with Stan Kenton that we couldn't check in every night you know. We would get to maybe some weeks, three or four nights of a hotel, the rest of the time just riding the bus, getting to the next gig, 500 miles in between things. Run in, shave, shower, put the suit on, run back. Stan always kept the buses freezing cold — pull on a winter coat even though it was summertime, and go on to the next one. Then those were kind of tough, kind of rough things to do. But I wouldn't trade it for anything.

MR: Why did Stan keep the buses cold?

TP: I don't know. He was always warm. He would get on the bus and — we were — so I'd been, I was living in New York at the time. And I bought a heavy, heavy winter coat and that's what we had — we rode in the bus with those things on and he had the bus down to like 62 or 60. Really cold. Sometimes colder. And sometimes he'd open the window.

MR: It's warmer outside.

TP: Yeah. And the buses back then weren't exactly like the buses now either. They were pretty B flat.

MR: Pretty B flat. Did you — I would imagine that bad habits — I'll just use that term — probably occurred because of that life.

TP: It was a tough life but I can speak for the bands I've been with, but okay I'll stick with Stan for a minute. Stan didn't put up with any drug use or anything like that. He was very fussy about that. If he found somebody he would send them off. So they didn't have a

MR: Yeah. This is of course pre-cell phone, pre-walkman, what did you fellas do to pass the time?

TP: Oh well we all had earphones we could put on some kind of music that we wanted to hear. Speaking of that, no cells, no this, no communication at all. It takes a very understanding wife because I couldn't be in touch with her a lot of the times. We'd be in areas where we were traveling and we didn't have any access to a phone or time to make a phone call until we checked in someplace. So it took a good woman to put up with us.

MR: And you have kids, right?

TP: Yeah, two.

MR: I bet they learned what the word gig meant early on.

TP: Yes.

MR: Did you miss out on some of their things that you wanted to get to or had you settled in one place by that time?

TP: Well I didn't have the children — after I got out of the service I moved to New York and we didn't have any children at that point. And then when I moved to Vegas to join Harry James we didn't have any children yet. And when we had our first child, my daughter, I did about six months with that — and that's when I told Stan — I mean Harry — I said, "This is too hard, I don't think I can do this anymore." However, we used to work 50 weeks a year and we were mostly in Nevada: Reno, Tahoe, Vegas. Reno, Tahoe, Vegas. And we'd go on the road two weeks in the spring, two weeks in the fall. But it got to the point like with the child, packing all the stuff you have to pack and loading the car and then it doesn't fit and then it snowed in Reno I mean so that's when I told Harry I said, "I'm going to have to leave. I would love to stay but I need to be home."

MR: And you're going to replace the gig with Harry James with what?

TP: Vic Damone.

MR: Vic Damone.

TP: The great singer. Had great charts, really good charts. J. Hill did a bunch of them. And that was a great job too. He worked Vegas a lot, every year. And occasionally we'd go out for maybe like a weekend to Philadelphia to Palumbo's or something and go out. But I worked with him and actually I replaced Buddy Childers there. Buddy Childers was the trumpet player for Vic and I replaced him. I stayed for a couple of years. And then my children were really small I got asked to play at the ABC Television in Los Angeles for the TV shows. Remember "Hollywood Palace" I don't know if you remember that.

MR: Sure.

TP: That was the last of the live shows by the way, no fixes. No fixes. That and then Pat Paulson "Half a Comedy Hour" it was called. And that was a small band. That was two

was playing bass. Jack Sperling was playing drums, I forget who the saxophone player was. Did that. And the reason I moved to L.A., Vic Damone — I had a lot of exposure with Vic Damone. They wrote a couple of charts where I had a chance to play — be featured like. And the conductor for "Hollywood Palace" happened to be in town and came to that show and he heard me play and he asked me if I'd like to come down and be lead trumpet player at "Hollywood Palace." And I talked to Vic and I told Vic about it and Vic says, "Well how much are you making?" And I told him. He said, "I'll give you more." So he made me an offer I couldn't refuse. So I stayed another year. The following year I got sounded again to go down and do it and I did it. And the reason I really did that is I wanted to put a check on myself. Am I good enough to be a top studio player? You know, when the heat's on. Am I good enough to play as well as those guys? And I did that and I went down and I found out that I was. That satisfied my feeling about how my playing was. Because I had never played with that caliber player — we had good caliber players here but they're top notch guys down there. John Audino and all those guys.

MR: Yeah I was going to ask who you were sitting next to in those days?

TP: Well at the "Hollywood Palace" it was pretty impressive, I'll tell ya. "Hollywood Palace" was Manny Klein, Ray Triscari, Sweets Edison and myself. That was one show. And we did the "Tom Jones Show" that was Audino, Ray Triscari, Jimmy Zito and myself. And at both of those shows every time something would come in with some Gs or stuff like that, Manny Klein would go, "Pass that to the kid." So I used to get all of that because they didn't want to play it so they'd pass it to me. And then I say like the small band, just Conte Candoli and myself.

MR: You know I was going to ask you about that passing the part because Bobby Shew had a similar story, that he was complaining about the high parts and Dalton Smith said, "Don't you know about this thing called 'pass it on?'"

TP: Yeah. One of the things you have to learn, well you know the funny part is, with Stan Kenton you couldn't pass. He would not allow the lead — you played lead trumpet you played every single chart. He would not allow passing.

MR: Even if you were having an off night?

TP: Didn't matter. You're not supposed to have off nights.

MR: In the fine print in your contract.

TP: Off nights. When you're playing that hard like in the Kenton band, to sit on top of that big a band, number one it was a thrill to do that, in really a good high spot. But it's — what was I going to say? I kind of lost my train of thought there.

MR: Yeah. Did you find it harder — some of the arrangers that wrote for Kenton were pretty harmonically advanced and if there was a spot in the chart, sometimes the last chord

perhaps, where everybody in the section was playing fairly high, especially you, and it was a thick, almost like a tone cluster — is it harder to find that note?

TP: Yeah. If that's what you need you're going to put 100% trust in yourself. If I had to play a high F and I've got a guy pushing me with an E flat next to it, and stuff like that, you've just got to know where it is and just go for it. And that's the only way you can do it because if you start listening to what's going on — so you have to have a lot of confidence. And I know where the high F lays on my horn. I know where this lays. So you just push the first valve down and let it fly.

MR: Was there ever any figuring out — okay the bass trombone player is ending on a low B flat and I can hear that and so I know where my F is in relation?

TP: Yeah. It helps if you can have that relation. Yeah. But it is, when you first start, you know I went out with Stan Kenton I was working Roseland Ballroom with a society band from Chicago. I didn't even get out of the staff. The next night I'm playing lead with Stan Kenton. It's kind of frightening.

MR: You didn't even get into the staff, right? Wow that's a lot of pressure. And in sort of doing some preparation for this I was noticing the names Rubino, Triscari, Candoli, Morrello, Gozzo. And the vowels at the ends of these names, like what is it with the Italian brass player? Does it go back to the marching bands do you think?

TP: I don't know what it is. I always make a joke and say we're the only ones dumb enough to want to play — to want to work that hard. No I don't know what it is, there are a darm lot of — yeah that trumpet section with Tom Jones, it was a total Italian trumpet section.

MR: Wow. I've noticed a couple of interesting little things along the way and I'll mention two of them. I used to do a show with an Elvis act here locally. And we used to play that tune "American Trilogy." And then I read somewhere that you were on that original recording, is that right?

TP: Yes.

MR: Yeah that had a marvelous — about 3/4 of the way through a very powerful brass thing. It sounded as if you're playing "Glory, Glory, Hallelujah."

TP: Yeah that's — I was playing lead on that. Yeah that horn, you were playing full out. You were playing like triple forte you know, it was loud. But yeah, the thing is remember, I was younger then and this sounds egotistical but I don't mean it to be egotistical but I don't go that route. But you couldn't tire me out in those days. I could play forever. When I was doing those six shows a day and I never thought about getting tired. And I might attribute that part to the Italian band, but I don't know.

MR: Did you have something that you did with your diet or exercise or whatever, to just keep yourself in shape?

MR: You've got the karma for it I guess.

TP: I guess you know. I was kind of like blessed I think as far as the range goes you know. I think that was kind of a natural gift I got to be able to play that altissimo register. So it never was like difficult for me, playing a bunch of charts some of them are screamers and some of them were not so bad, so it leveled out, and I could do it all. I could cover it.

MR: There are certain tunes that almost require an answer. Musically, yesterday I got out a chart I had written for my sax ensemble and it was a James Brown thing and before we played it I said, all right remember these are college aged students, I said "All right everybody, give me the proper response" and I said, [sings] "I feel good" and they all went [scats]. So I'm going to try one out on you, if I sing "Sweet Caroline." —

TP: [Scats response]. Three famous notes.

MR: Three famous notes.

TP: Three famous notes, I've done so many things in my career. Now my students call me up after that — he heard that — he said, "Oh Mr. Porrello, you're awesome" for those three notes.

MR: Do you particularly remember that session?

TP: Yeah. Because everything is pieced together. We went in, the brass section, we went in by ourselves with the headphones on. The rhythm section was already on you know. It wasn't done as a group. The rhythm section went on, then the horns go on, and then maybe the strings if there are strings. But you never know who you're recording for. The voice is the last thing to go on. So we had to be told by the contractor that we were on a million seller.

MR: Wow. Too bad you didn't get paid by the note.

TP: Yeah.

MR: What that note is worth, because it's like a cultural icon now. You play that tune and everybody is singing Tom Porrello's trumpet part.

TP: Yeah, right. And in Boston they play it at every Boston baseball game. And I'm a Yankee fan so I don't know if I —

MR: Oh that's priceless. Do you recall the first time that you did that? I remember reading an anecdote about Phoebe Snow the singer invited Teddy Wilson to come in and play on a tune of hers and so he got there and they sat him at the piano and he said, "Where's the band?" And they gave him the headphones and he didn't know, "What are you talking about, where's the band?" He had never done the overdubbing. And do you recall the first time you ever did it?

TP: The overdubbing thing?

MR: Yes.

TP: In L.A. in the studios, when I was there. That's the way almost everything was done that way. Very seldom did the entire band get together and play. Like Sinatra always kept the full band when he recorded. He didn't do it the other way. Vic Damone, he did it with a full band.

MR: Do they put them in a booth or something?

TP: Yeah. They'd have a little thing off to the side and then, you know, then they go in the booth and they listen to it, if they liked the way they sounded or if they liked the way the band sounded, and if it was okay, good, we'd move on to the next chart. Back then we used to do a lot of charts in one recording session. Now they record something and it takes three months. And you know, and the new thing they're doing is before you go in they go to the computer and they send you your part so you can woodshed it before you get there.

MR: No kidding.

TP: Yeah. So — sight reading was one of the main — if you're going to be a studio player you'd better be a good sight reader because that's all you do is sight read. You don't rehearse anything or you don't get the parts in advance. So you had to be a good sight reader. Now they send that stuff out. I did a couple Broadway shows and before I ever went for the first rehearsal I had the whole book on the computer.

MR: I think I know the answer to this question but in a situation like let's say Vic Damone or live, did they ever have to do another take that was fine except for Tom Porrello's part?

TP: Not often. Not often, but there were a few times, but I can't remember any of them.

MR: Good.

TP: Trying to be consistent you know and accurate, accurate. That helps. But then the other thing which you may have, when I would ask a student I say "What do I mean when I say you've got to be consistent?" And they say, "Well that means you don't have to clam a note." I said, "No, that's not what I'm talking about." "Well what are you talking about?" "Okay if you're going to be a lead trumpet player you have to be very disciplined. You have to phrase, you have to lengthen the notes, everything has to be exactly the same every time you play it because you've got the rest of the band on your shoulders." You can't play it short one night and long the next. So that's what — like Harry's band was so damn tight, they used to talk about Les Brown's being tight, Harry's band was unbelievably tight. You know and everything was — and with the Kenton band when I joined the Kenton band the previous lead player had things marked and Stan gave me a prerogative to say if you want to change anything change it but make sure everybody knows. Make sure the bones know and the rest of the trumpets. So that works you know.

MR: I'm glad you brought that up because I was thinking about arrangers and the music that

more specific about what you're talking about. You know these quarter notes have caps on them and if they don't have anything does that become more your decision about how to deal with it?

TP: Yeah. You know there are a lot of the arrangers too that are not brass players. Some of the markings they put are not what they want. If you play exactly what they wrote and they play it and they go, "No, no, no. That note's got to be long." I said, "Well it's got a cap on it." They say, "Oh okay well fix it." And you fix it and you play it that way every single time after that.

MR: Did you ever have any sort of philosophical disagreements with the drummers about how things are supposed to go?

TP: No. I didn't have much choice. I had really good luck with drummers. On Harry James I had Buddy Rich for four years. Then when he left Sonny Payne — I mean Louie Bellson came on for a couple of months, then Sonny Payne came. So I couldn't argue much with those three. No, it was just a natural feel. The first night I played I flew out from New York and went to Lake Tahoe and played. Sat down and played and you know, was comfortable with Buddy right away. And he was comfortable with me right away, luckily, 'cause you want to get along with him.

MR: I have it from an inside source that he used to massage your shoulders or something afterwards, to sort of help you get through the night.

TP: Well a couple times we did a TV show in Chicago. All the big bands did it. And they went to WGN and they recorded it and then they made videotapes for home use and they used to play it on TV in New York. And it had an arch, and the band was playing there. So we did that with Harry and I think I've had a migraine headache probably two times in my life and I had one that day. I literally thought I was going to die. But when I stopped — when I was blowing I was okay, soon as the air stopped the room would just go like this. And I said, "Well Jesus." So Buddy saw that and I took a little break, he came over and he massaged my shoulders and it helped me out, and then Harry got in on it. You want me to tell you what Harry said?

MR: Sure.

TP: "Have a glass of vodka."

MR: Yeah. He solved that issue long ago, right? He knew what to do. You're not a — of course I can't really tell in Zoom, but I've seen you on the bandstand with some videos. You seem to be smaller than most lead trumpet players, who often have some heft to them.

TP: Right.

MR: Yeah. I don't have a question there but you're a physically strong guy but you're small.

TP: Yeah well I'm 5'5-1/2 — I was, I think I shrunk a little bit. 5'5-1/2. We have a book here called *The Kenton Chronicles* and it's all guys that played with Stan, wrote pieces, and Jiggs Wiggam, you know Jiggs, trombone player — well Jiggs was my roommate on the band. And he wrote that in the book, he said, "Tommy came on and played, what was it, 'Yesterdays' where the trumpet goes [scats] up to high G." And said, "He's kind of a small guy," he said, "but he got that out. Stan got a big smile on his face and he got hired." Yeah I just — you know if you breathe properly it takes some of the stress off the chops otherwise you don't bang 'em up and cut 'em up. If you follow — Bobby Shew's got a set thing that he teaches and I have a little thing that I use too, you know just getting the air to the diaphragm first, like yawning, and then sucking air up like [gasps] like that. And then third, when you blow, grasp the air and your stomach becomes hard so you're pushing your stomach towards your back. And that's one of the reasons some trumpet players have back problems. But by doing those three steps you're setting up like a combustion chamber within your body. And that takes all the — the sound projects better, your endurance is better, and everything is better. So I think I compensated that because I did that correctly and by gift. I never worked on that. That's just the way I did it when I first started to play.

MR: That's good luck right there. The Kenton band came to my college where I was at SUNY Fredonia around 1970 so of course after they left we decided to play Kenton arrangements. And in talking with you I now can recall thinking about what those guys behind me were doing. I was in the saxophone section and like we would play "Here's That Rainy Day" and that brass build-up, the whole chart builds up to this [scats] and I remember thinking wow, are they going to get it this time.

TP: Well Kenton ballads are like no other ballads. They're about half the tempo of most bands' ballads. I mean everything is like [hums]. We were in Denver once working and we were playing the theme [hums]. Well the guy next to me, the third trumpet, he plays a high D and he has to hold it for eight counts at that tempo. Then I come in and I pick up the D and I go to a high G for eight counts. And while I was playing I looked over and this guy was going [mimes about to fall] so I stopped and grabbed him by the back of his coat. Because Denver, the altitude's high there anyway. But you have to really pace your air in a Kenton ballad. You've got to. It's very difficult. Because it's loud and you've got to pace. You've got to know how much to give and don't go past that or you're not going to make it. So you have to work on that. But age, everybody's different of course, but if you know what you have to do you have to realize somewhere in your head, when you take your breath you're going to have to go from here to here.

MR: Yeah. You can't — even if Kenton's like, "Come on, give me some more sound," you

TP: He never had to go like that. We were out, full out, the whole time. I was playing a Benge trumpet then, Jesus, that thing, man. When I got rid of that horn and changed to something different the lead pipe and the mouthpiece holder — well there's supposed to be a little gap as far as the mouthpiece goes in and then this is raised. It's the lead pipe. The guy said, "Who the hell played this trumpet, man" he said, "it's gone, the whole thing is gone, it's just a straight pipe." So I don't know. It's funny.

MR: I can see the trumpet players who will watch this interview like chuckling right now at that sort of inside story. Did you ever have an opportunity to play either with Basie or with a band very similar to Basie? Because I'm wondering what the difference is between Kenton and, you know, a swinging group like Basie?

TP: Basie is a swing band and everything that Basie — when it's short it's [scats] that kind of thing [scats] you know. And we didn't have too many figures like that with the stuff we were playing with Stan. That album they did with the yellow cover, with Al Porcino and all those guys, they had some charts like that. But it was short. Jiggs and I used to mess around once in a while and when we'd play one of those tunes off of that album we would cut the notes short and Stan would, "This is not Woody's band" he'd say, "don't play 'em short."

MR: There's a funny anecdote about Stan and I don't know if I would call it his aversion to swinging but it wasn't his main goal. Is that a fair statement?

TP: He loved Wagner. You know he liked that — big blocks of sound. That's what he was going after, the sound. He loved that big sound of the thing. He wasn't against swinging but he didn't have many charts that were ultra-ultra swinging you know. It was a whole different approach kind of thing, almost a little more orchestral like, you know?

MR: You became a first-call trumpet player in Las Vegas, and I guess it was similar to the studios like just be ready to do anything?

TP: Yeah. You know we played for everybody from country & western to swinging, to Sinatra, to Frank, Sammy, Dean, Tony Bennett, Barbra Streisand. We played for all those people. Each hotel had a 25-piece orchestra. That's long gone. So whoever appeared at that hotel we played for them. And we would knock that out, usually in a three hour rehearsal.

MR: That was my question. Would the artist be there or not?

TP: Most of the time. A few of them wouldn't. Like when we do the Motown, the Temps and the Tops and all that, no, they'd just have a conductor and not even a rhythm section. The conductor had a cowbell and he'd ding-ding-ding-ding and we'd have to play all the charts with them hitting the cowbell.

MR: Oh man.

TP: Anyway you know I've even done, believe it or not, almost anything from — all the way back to like I did one thing with Metallica and one thing with Deep Purple. You want to talk about loud.

MR: Yeah. Metallica, I mean a couple guitars and amplifiers can cover up a — it doesn't matter how many pieces you've got.

TP: We did the thing they did with the San Francisco Symphony. So this was a Grammy show or something, and we did some, so I did that. We played for everybody no matter what. Short time rehearsal, sight reading again, you've got to be a good sight reader. And all the guys, a lot of the top trumpet players, came, you know, while we're here, Bobby Shew was here, I'm here, Charlie Davis was here, John Audino for a while. A lot of guys started here and went off into the studios. In fact Chuck Findley and I moved to L.A. in the same week. He used to come over my house all the time and we'd shoot — the house I rented had a pool table and we'd shoot pool. He stayed and I was not crazy about — I liked the caliber of players that I played with, I loved the studio. Because playing in a showroom here is very difficult, because they're usually padded with heavy drapery so it really eats the sound up, so you've got to push and it's beyond the days when everybody had their own mic, there was no mics at all except for maybe a flute solo or something. We just played live.

MR: What about with Lady Gaga now? I mean that must be a high tech show. Are they micing everything in the band?

TP: Yeah.

MR: And do you have in-ear monitors now?

TP: We have in-ear monitors, yeah. And most of the guys use them. I don't.

MR: I don't blame you.

TP: I don't. I don't like 'em. I can hear the drums fine, for time. He was way over but I could hear him fine. And I don't like — I can't get used to, even when you're recording you put one on and take the other one off so you can hear the guy next to you better. I'm not a fan of those but a lot of guys do it and it works good for them. I wasn't about to get used to that, I just play without it and I'm fine. I, you know, we do Gaga, I could hear, I don't need to hear myself either because when I'm playing I can literally hear the sound bouncing off the back wall and coming back at me so I don't need to hear myself through an earpiece.

MR: Can you recall the first time, or early on, when the technology thing raised its head, like what's this synthesizer thing doing here?

TP: [inaudible] That knocked out a lot of people out of work.

MR: About when — do you recall about when that was occurring? Starting?

MR: Say it again?

TP: '70s maybe.

MR: Yeah. That would have been the height of when a lot of those, at that time hi-tech keyboards came out. First probably the string section went and —

TP: Yeah the string section. But some guys, in the beginning, guys didn't know how to write for it either so it really sounded not well at all. Later on some of the guys, they learned how to write for it and they sounded pretty decent first, like the string section. But in the beginning oh it was terrible.

MR: Yeah you had a cheap sound and a cheap part.

TP: Yeah, well, it knocked out a whole string section.

MR: Um hum.

TP: 15, 20 strings.

MR: Who were the arrangers, did you have particular arrangers that you loved to see their name up in that right hand corner of page one?

TP: Yeah. I mean common things. You know Harry had great charts. Basie, great charts. And Stan — you know those are bands I played with and I liked every one of them for a different reason. But Basie and Harry, you know at the tail end we played a lot of Basie charts. They're not the same charts, let me clarify that. We played a lot of stuff that was written by Basie's people or written for Harry's band. We played a lot of that. So you say which band was kind of like — Harry's band was getting close to Basie you know. In fact we used to do a thing — he wanted to play those. He didn't want to play "You Made Me Love You" and all that stuff anymore you know. So when they were at the Flamingo at the hotel they were calling for this and all that so on the break we talked a little bit and you know Harry — they come here to hear that, so why don't you like put together 8 or 16 bars of each of those things that were big hits for you way back then. Once you get those out of the way then you play anything you want. And he did. He got it, he put a nice medley together of his hits and boom, now we could play the Basie charts, we could play anything we wanted.

MR: That's a good compromise. And were people dancing to his band?

TP: No. No we worked in the lounges here in Las Vegas.

MR: I see.

TP: The lounges are all like 300, 400 seaters. But we would play at the Flamingo Hotel, we played on the high stage and below us was the bar, and above us was like a dome. And it had corks like hanging — short ones, short ones, to like keep the sound down so it wasn't too loud in the casino. So it was a hard place to play. But every time, it would never fail, I'd be with Harry's band and Frank Sinatra Junior would come in with somebody — I got

chops. You know. It was a hard place to play. But again, you've got to keep an open mind. You've got to pace yourself. You've got to know how much to give and how much to ease off.

MR: I would think that ego has a bit to do with that, like you — people, I can imagine always want to impress if you're lead trumpet player and you always want to impress, that that could lead to some of that physical injury?

TP: Trumpet players sometimes we're not the smartest people. We're used to hearing what we want to hear coming out of that bell. And if we don't hear it we're silly enough to do extra to make yourself hear what you want to hear. I always used to teach my students that the way to do that, for me, the way I do that, well I can tell by my stomach how much I'm pumping, how much air I'm pumping. I can feel that. If it gets beyond that, because I don't hear myself, then I know I'm looking to get hurt so I back off a little bit. I can tell by right here — I don't want to go any louder than that, even if I don't hear myself as well.

MR: Was there a difference in playing in formerly smoky nightclubs than when they weren't later?

TP: With Stan and Woody we did some nightclubs. We didn't do a lot of those with Stan. We did some, did some, but more it was like concert halls and theaters and stuff like that. So yeah, luckily I didn't have too much of a bad time with those things with all the smoke coming. Of course I was a smoker back then too.

MR: I was going to ask, and like you said how important lungs are to this whole affair that you do, so it's pretty amazing that you could be a smoker and do that.

TP: Okay well number one I didn't smoke until I went in the Navy. So I was about 23 or 24 when I first started to smoke. And I smoked for quite a while and then I got a little — every once in a while when I'd go to take a good nice deep one I'd feel like a little zing. And I thought hmm, I think it's trying to tell me something. So I quit smoking and that's about 40 years ago now. And that went away but it scared me when I felt that little ping, right, like a sharp — I thought I've got to stop this. So I did and it paid off.

MR: I'm glad you did that. A couple of more questions and then we'll wrap up. If you got nostalgic, you felt nostalgic and you wanted to hear a particular LP and a particular tune that you really did shine on and you went and got the LPs out, what would that song be?

TP: There'd be a couple of them. One of my favorites, again, is "The Toothless Grin" with Woody's band. The story behind that, I was working at a hotel and I got called about — we played midnight until by the time I got home it was 2:30, and they said, "Can you get the first flight out tomorrow and fly down to San Francisco and finish this recording with us." And I said — you know I had to call the band leader and get the okay and I went

chart out and the band of course had played it on the road so they were well aware of it and they didn't have to sight read it. But I had to sight read it. And I don't know it was just swinging so good and everything, I just got into it and just let it fly you know. And there's two tunes, the tune before that is a ballad too, "Come Rain or Come Shine." Those are the two. "Come Rain or Come Shine" and "Toothless Grin" those are the last two that I did. Then there was another one I did but it's on a different Woody album. I don't even know what that one is anymore. But it was fun with Woody Herman too.

MR: Did you get some appreciative looks that day, in that situation?

TP: Absolutely yeah. In fact the trombone player said, "Jesus Christ, how long ago did Bill send you that chart?" I said, "Bill didn't send me the chart, I'm looking at it right now."

MR: Would that have been Bill Holman?

TP: No. No. On that particular album with Woody, that wouldn't have been him.

MR: Okay I just wondered about the arranger who did that?

TP: Oh it was — you would know his name. He's actually one of Woody's musicians who wrote the chart.

MR: Oh. A sax player perhaps?

TP: Yeah one of them was, "Come Rain or Come Shine" but he lives here in town too. I should know his name, he's going to be bummed if I don't remember his name now. He's a very talented writer. He wrote "Come Rain or Come Shine." I think somebody like — I think the drummer, one of the drummers wrote "Come Rain" or the other one, "Toothless Grin." Boy that's got a kicking out-chorus on it.

MR: Well we'll look it up.

TP: Yeah. I think you'll like it.

MR: Okay, last question. In the Sunday *New York Times* magazine they always interview an author who's just put out some new book and they ask them all the same question: If you could arrange a dinner party of authors both living and not living, who would you invite? So my question to you is if you could do such a thing with lead trumpet players, to have a dinner party, who would be your short list of guests?

TP: John Audino.

MR: John Audino.

TP: Chuck Findley. Ray Triscari. You know those are guys that are all gone now but they were heavy, heavy duty players man. Today some of the guys in Tower of Power, they play really well. You know there's — we have a band here in Vegas called — what the hell's the name of it — Jerry Lopez has got a band and it's Fat City Horns. And they are kicking. But that's an incredible band. And the lead trumpet player in that is Danny Falcone who was a student of mine, and his father was the conductor for Sinatra for a lot

of years. And Danny's playing lead on that and he's playing incredibly well. So he would definitely be invited too.

MR: Do you think you guys would talk shop like okay what mouthpiece are you playing now?

TP: Oh that goes on all the time. My wife always breaks up if anybody comes over the house and says, "You guys can talk about trumpets and mouthpieces for like three days without stopping." But I'll tell you something funny about me. I'm not much of a changer like a lot of them are. Some guys have over 100 mouthpieces. I played a Bach 10-3/4 CW when I was a kid in high school and all that. And when I moved to LA I switched to a Bob Reeves mouthpiece. But he copied it except for the backbore, he copied if off of that mouthpiece. So the Bob Reeves, I still play that one. So I've had like two mouthpieces since the time I was a kid. You know if it works don't mess with it. You know?

MR: I'm with you on that.

TP: Yeah. And the horns, they make so many good ones now. I did most of my career on a Benge trumpet and then I switched over about twenty years ago to a Bach sterling silver, which the whole bell section is sterling silver. So for me, that horn like really projects. It projects, it's got a good fat sound and I do most of my work on that now.

MR: Nice.

TP: But I'm sure I left out a lot of great trumpet players that I'd invite, but off the top of my head quick I can't —

MR: Well I would call Snooky Young and tell him about the party so he could go too.

TP: He definitely would be there. That's for sure. Yeah definitely. We have Tom Delibero, he's a local trumpet player here, he's a great player too. He definitely be sure — yeah there are so many good ones you know. Chase used to live here.

MR: Bill Chase? Yeah.

TP: He used to live here. I used to — when I lived in New York I was doing "Funny Girl" with Barbra Streisand in the pit. And on my way home I had to pass the club, with the jazz club there and Bill would be playing with Woody. And we didn't talk a whole bunch but then after I got off Stan Kenton's band then all of a sudden we were good friends. Then he moved out here and when I left Vic Damone I got Bill to take my place, when I went to LA to get to the studios. And we became good friends. Another Italian trumpet player by the way. Bill Chase. Yeah, his name is not Chase.

MR: Okay. Yeah it took up too much space on the record.

TP: Yeah. I want to say one more thing about the band leaders, how they differ.

MR: Yeah I'd love to hear that.

TP: Stan was like — if you played with Stan Kenton you're part of the family. That's the way he treats you, like you're family. When you ask him, "Who's the greatest lead trumpet

said the same thing to the next guy. We played once in Hollywood and we played in a club and behind me were like four ex-Kenton trumpet players looking over my shoulder. And Stan after he got done Stan gave me a big hug and that's the way he dealt with it. And Harry was always great, he liked me a lot luckily. He left a little space between him and a lot of the band, you know. Not that he was arrogant with anybody, but he wasn't like, it wasn't exactly like family like Stan's was. And Woody, he was just a good — have a good time. My playing with Woody asked me to stay after the recording until they found somebody so I stayed for a couple, three weeks or something. And I said to Bill Byrne who was the manager, who was also in the Naval Academy band with me, Bill Byrne. I said, "Woody, when he has a new lead trumpet player he doesn't call [scats], that figure on top of the — I forget what tune it was even.

MR: Oh yeah.

TP: It starts on a double C. [scats] So I said he doesn't ever do that. He said, "Never." He called it the fourth tune. Luckily I nailed it for him. Oh boy.

MR: Well you had some confidence in your own abilities that's for sure.

TP: Yeah. And my father always made sure that I didn't let ego get in my way. My father was — "We don't do any ego crap." You know? "If you play good that's great. That's what you need to do. Don't — you don't need to tell people how good you play. If you play good they'll hear it. So don't get that ego trip going." So I never did.

MR: You know that's a very quotable, Tom, so that's the best way I can think to end this session, and I very much appreciate your time and you've been a joy to talk to.

TP: Well likewise. It's good to see what you look like, and I guess you see what I look like too. I was really concerned that this whole thing wasn't going to happen because you know I do everything on the computer, I do banking and do all this stuff. But I did one Zoom thing for that "Trumpet Players over 50" — oh what a disaster. "Can you hear me?" "No I can't hear you." "Wait fix that." Luckily I had Danny Falcone here next to me, no hit this button, do that. This was like a piece of cake. This was nice.

MR: Well good. All right.

TP: Well I hope I get to meet you in person sometime.

MR: I hope so. I think I should come out to Las Vegas.

TP: Yeah well we don't have a hell of a lot going on for horn players now. There's plenty of work for trios and a saxophone player right now. There are very few things using a horn. I sub right now at the Rat Pack shows, about Sammy, Frank, and Dean, and that's got like two trumpets, a trombone and a sax. Four horns. And that gets a good little blow for you, you know. It gets me out of the practice room. I get tired of listening to myself. Like you've got to play with a band once in a while. It's like a sport, you can't just practice

MR: Well said. All right. Thanks a lot.

TP: Okay, my pleasure.